

Varanus albigularis

Savanna monitor



Location E., C., and southern Africa

Length 3¼ ft (1 m), max 6 ft (1.8 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Status Not evaluated



crossbands

Also known as the white-throated monitor, this lizard has powerful limbs for digging burrows, in which it lives; it also lives in hollow tree trunks. Territorial, with a range of up to 7 square miles (18 square km), it forages for birds, insects, snails, and invertebrates. Its chief predators are martial eagles and rats, and it is sometimes eaten by humans, despite legal protection. In defense, the savanna monitor puffs up its throat and body, lashes out with its tail, and bites. In a year, a female may lay 2 clutches of as many as 50 eggs.

Varanus varius

Lace monitor



Location E. Australia

Length 5–6½ ft (1.5–2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated



Dark gray or bluish, with white or cream markings, the lace monitor has a long neck and tail, and long claws used for scaling trees. It bites and lashes out with its tail if threatened. It forages on the ground and in trees for insects, reptiles, birds and their eggs, and small mammals. Females lay 6–12 eggs in holes in termite mounds, which the termites seal; reportedly, females sometimes return to help the young dig their way out.



Varanus dumerilii

Dumeril's monitor



Location S.E. Asia

Length 3¼–4¼ ft (1–1.3 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Status Not evaluated



indistinct light markings

narrow head

Although this slender gray lizard is mostly terrestrial, it is also a good swimmer, and can close its nostrils underwater when in pursuit of crabs to eat. It also forages actively for insects, birds, and bird and turtle eggs. It may occasionally enter the sea to escape from predators, mainly mammals and snakes, which threaten young lizards in particular, or may escape by climbing into trees and shrubs. Males are territorial during the breeding season; after mating, females lay their eggs in soil or leaf litter. This monitor prefers mangrove forests but also inhabits forests away from the coast.

Varanus niloticus

Nile monitor



Location Africa (mainly south of Sahara)

Length 4½–6½ ft (1.4–2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Not evaluated



whiplike tail used for swimming and defense

The grayish brown Nile monitor is never found far from water. It basks on nearby rocks or tree stumps, and feeds on crabs, mollusks, fishes, and frogs, as well as birds, eggs, and carrion. Hunted by crocodiles and pythons, it uses its tail, claws, and teeth to defend itself. In the cooler part of its range, it hibernates in communal "dens." Females lay 20–60 eggs in termite mounds, and the hatchlings dig their way out after rain has softened the earth.

beadlike scales



Varanus prasinus

Green tree monitor



Location New Guinea

Length 30–39 in (75–100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern



Well equipped for its arboreal way of life, this species has a light, slender body that enables it to support itself on narrow branches, and a coloration that helps to camouflage it against the trees.

It feeds on insects, small vertebrates, crabs, and birds' eggs. When threatened, it flees through vegetation and may bite if cornered. One of the few monitors that are social by nature, it appears to live in small groups made up of a dominant male, several females, and subordinate males and juveniles. Females lay clutches of up to 6 eggs in a hole in arboreal termite nests or leaf litter.



long claws grip bark

Varanus flavirufus

Sand monitor



Location S. New Guinea, Australia

Length 30–39 in (75–100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Status Not evaluated



This impressive reptile has a slender, powerful body that varies in color from pale yellow to dark gray, but it almost always has a dark line extending from the back of the eye to the neck. The tail works as a prop when the monitor stands on its hind legs, but when threatened, it uses its tail as a whip or club. A voracious feeder, the sand monitor eats mammals, birds, and other reptiles, as well as smaller animals and carrion. It shelters in burrows and in hollow trees, and females often lay their eggs in termite mounds, clawing them open to place the eggs inside.



Varanus bitatawa

Northern Sierra Madre forest monitor



Location Philippines

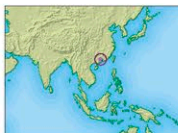
Length 6½ ft (2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Mostly arboreal
Status Not evaluated



Discovered in the northern Sierra Madre mountain forests of Luzon, in the Philippines, this spectacular giant monitor was described as a new species in 2010. Longer than a tall man, it has black upper parts blotched with golden spots and a black and green banded tail. The northern Sierra Madre forest monitor spends most of its life high in the trees, some 66 ft (20 m) above the ground, where it feeds almost exclusively on fruit. Its secretive habits and reluctance to cross open spaces probably explain why it eluded detection by scientists for so long. This species of forest monitor is separated from its closest ally in the southern part of the island by a 93-mile (150-km) gap across a low-lying river valley.

Shinisaurus crocodilurus

Chinese crocodile lizard



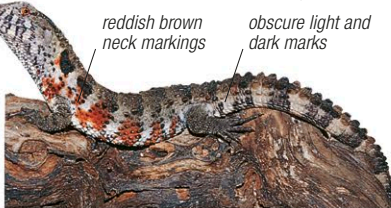
Location E. Asia (Kwangsi Province, China)

Length 16–18 in (40–46 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Endangered



This rare, little-known lizard is olive in color, with rows of enlarged, bony scales down its back and tail, like those of a crocodile. The male is more colorful than

the female but perhaps only in the breeding season. To escape detection, the lizard may "freeze" for several hours at a time, even in midstride—a tactic that, along with its coloration, helps it to merge with its surroundings. It adapts in unusual ways to cool temperatures: it may, for instance, be able to "shut down" its system for hours to conserve energy during very cold nights. The female gives birth to 2–10 young, sometimes over several days.



reddish brown neck markings

obscure light and dark marks